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News You Can Use

News is the in thing these days. It's therefore natural that news aggregators are a talking point

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Anthing to do with computers and information technology and you'd have multiple formats and their multiple abbreviations. And don't blame the press for this state of affairs. It's the geek ego at play. So we have Really Simple Syndication and Rich Site Summary. We have RSS feeds and Atom Feeds. We have feed burners and then we have feed readers...

Now, if all this is end-user technology, why must an average computer user struggle with all this? What is a news aggregator? How does it function better than just going to the site directly and accessing all your information? Well, as you would have guessed, the questions are no-brainers, and as we proceed through the

article, you'll see how much easier and how much more convenient it is to have your own feed reader. Moreover, throughout the article, to maintain a level of uniformity and easy recall, all formats of feeds—whether RSS or Atom—would be referred to as RSS feeds or simply, feeds. Nothing personal against the Atom format, but RSS is a better-known acronym to remember.

Looking Before Leaping

Before we get headlong into the coded world of XML and RSS, we need to tackle a few points that people regularly miss out on—areas such as syndication, uses of a feed, and how setting up a feed increases the number of hits to your site. We have already discussed how to set up your own RSS feed (Tips & Tricks, *Digit*, June 2005).